

68

The Wichita Eagle

Sunday Morning, April 27, 1958

and a double header baseball game coming up — Braves vs. Bears, Sunday. So, the seasons were scrambled like a roadside comet.

Ben Geraghty smelled a conspiracy when he had notice that the Saturday afternoon ball game would be played, despite the conditions prevailing. There was snow on the car bumpers outside the swanky Continental Hotel-Motel where the team stayed for the first time. Lowering clouds and no signs of old sol were also evident. "Who will come out in this kind of weather," the Braves' boss grumbled.

Actually there was a bit of a conspiracy. Manager Andy Cohen of the Bears gave it away the evening before.

"You're going to get some help, probably two fine pitchers and an outfielder or infielder when Milwaukee makes the May cut," the Bears' pilot observed. And that was one reason why Denver was so eager to play. The Bears' den figured Wichita would be much tougher next trip, in June.

Low Attendance Prevails

Actually, baseball in 45 degree weather will not interest anyone much. Attendance at three games Friday in the Association was a combined 1877, with Omaha having 886 and the two games in the Twin Cities less than 1,000, with 526 at St. Paul and only 465 in the huge new Minneapolis Park.

So perhaps brother Phipps at Omaha has something.

Either get a new weather bureau, or a new baseball schedule with April games, if they must be played in the league, to be performed in the deep, deep south.

Denver baseball fans did not get to see the Milwaukee game on TV. It was blacked out because the Bears played an afternoon game, two hours after the TV game got under way.

Where's That Leader?

"What this club needs most is a leader," battling Ben Geraghty will readily admit.

One never masses the roses until the frost has come, the poets say.

And two infighting mainstays of last season are now being placed on the wished-for list. Harry Hanebrink was the ball player's player of the 1957 team. Harry hated to lose, he had but one interest in life, baseball and his value to the team was realized in the playoffs. When Hanebrink left the club it left the playoffs.

Bobby Malkmus was perhaps the most underestimated worthy of the '57 team. Both Ted Wilks and Geraghty think that Malkmus will be a regular at Washington, if they just give him a chance.

Slow Starters

"Morgan and Hersh have been slow starters, they'll come around, but we still don't have a Hanebrink," boss Ben worded it.

Geraghty and Coach Wilks pointed out a flaw in the Braves' thinking. "We send up a pinch hitter, we're four behind and need to get somebody on base, and he (Hartfield) swings at the first pitch and flies out. Then we get two walks. We would have had the bases full with no one out had he gotten on," Ben told it, as Ted shook his head, sad at thinking of the late fizzle.

Boots and Bingles

The death of Herman Hickman at a fairly young age hit the sports world with a terrific blow. Hickman was assistant coach at West Point and as we recall it, greeted Al Gebert and his men when Wichita U played the Army at the Point, 20 years ago next fall.—Dick Boushka had a big night of it when the USA cagers beat the Soviets. Russia had no scouts at the Denver National, where Dick was held not only scoreless but without a shot, in the last half by K. C. Jones and Co.—The defeat of the U.S. girls will be another convincing argument that the best looking girls may live in the 48 states, but Russia's massive femmes know their sports. The series, surprising as it would have seemed to the teams who played in the national tourneys in Wichita, will fail to convince many that the Tulsa Stenoe, or some of the teams coached by Sam Babb would not have taken the overseas trip, and won. However, chances are that they were playing straight men's rules in the Russian series, and that the U.S. girls had some new wrinkles to learn about the game.